BOOKS

GAME CHANGER

Professional wrestler Sakshi Malik's hard-hitting memoir is a tale of triumph against all odds

There are two key moments that Sakshi Malik will be best remembered for—the historic Olympic bronze at the Rio Games in 2016, and her unflinching stand in the sexual harassment case against former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh. Both epic battles, one on the mat and the other off it, that have come to define her invaluable contribution to Indian wrestling. In *Witness*, her biography co-written with sports journalist Jonathan Selvaraj, Sakshi revisits the journey that led to the two pivotal moments of her life, and which have changed the course of wrestling in the country.

It's easy to forget that India's first individual Olympic medal came in wrestling, way back in 1952, when K.D. Jadhav won bronze in Helsinki. After a long wait, Sushil Kumar won back-to-back medals at the Beijing and London Games in 2008 and 2012. The sport blossomed among male wrestlers at various *akharas* across the country, but until two decades ago when Sakshi first stepped on the mat as a 12-year-old, no Indian woman had even qualified for the Olympics.

It explains why she had a go at a few other sports until she discovered her love for wrestling. There was an instant connection and enough reason to tackle every challenge thrown at her. What followed were the well-documented travails of every Indian athlete. Fortunately for Sakshi, the first and only female grappler from India to win an Olympic medal, it culminated in glory and a change in fortunes.

Sakshi never tasted the same level of success again in the wrestling arena. But the reasons to fight for the things she believed in never left her, whether it was to marry the man she loved or shape the future of women's wrestling in India.

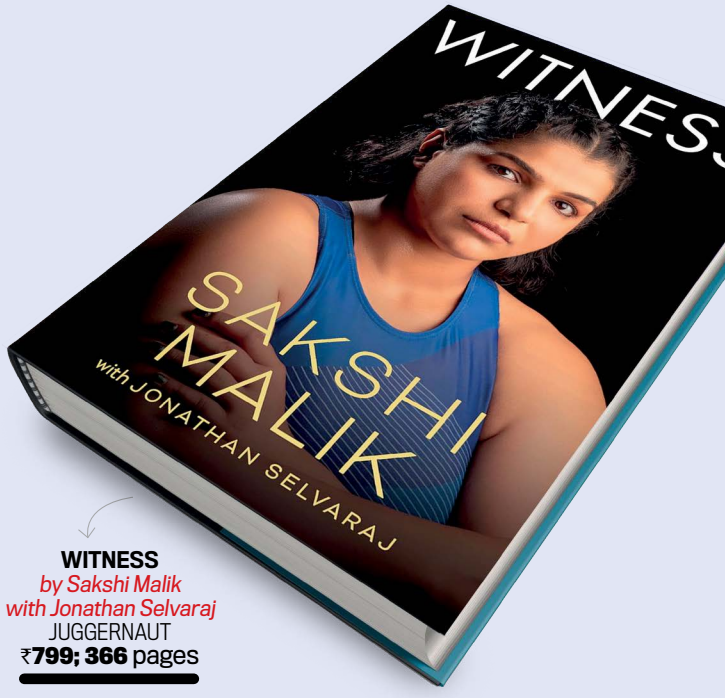
The many serious allegations against WFI chief Brij Bhushan meant someone had to take him on. From the highs of stepping on the podium, Sakshi had no qualms in hitting the streets for justice. She was often made to realise that it was perhaps for a lost cause, but athletes are made of sterner stuff and her time as a professional wrestler taught her never to call it quits. Then again, well aware of the fight she had taken on and the consequences of her actions, she decided to step away from competitive wrestling in 2023.

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Sakshi pulls no punches in calling out the folks in power and their conniving ways. The writing is straightforward and could have done with some colour, considering what Selvaraj has reported in the past. But it's the little details that stand out in the narrative and make it an engaging read. Like how Sakshi was tickled into submission by cops when their collective might couldn't take her down; the persistent doubts over her body image that she struggled with; the sheer delight of upgrading to business class after having taken long train journeys in the general compartment.

And an honest yet startling confession that she never quite enjoyed any form of confrontation, yet did just that to earn the things that she desired and deserved. ■

–Shail Desai



WITNESS
by Sakshi Malik with Jonathan Selvaraj
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